



Still Bears Her Name

Tracking Label-Refiller Match Across a Shared Kitchen's Spice Rack

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Motivation

Shared kitchens rely on a jar's handwritten label to signal who restocks it. Once written, a label routinely outlives the arrangement it recorded. How far can a name drift from the hand that refills it before anyone revises it?

Research questions

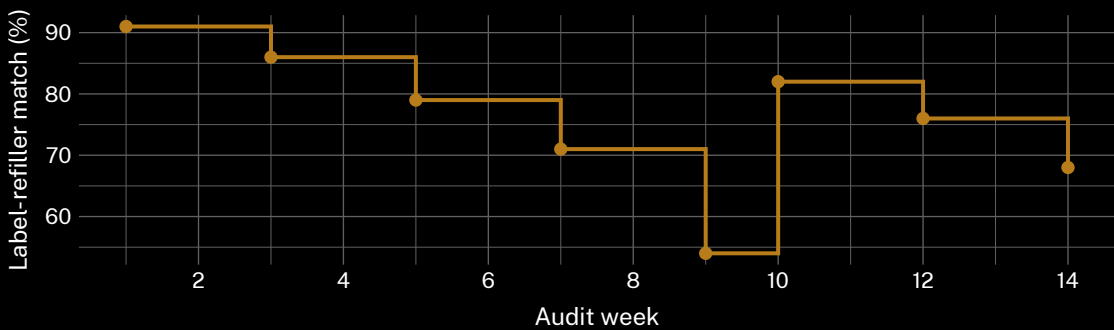
- Classify labelled jars by name-refiller match status across shared kitchens
- Track how long a mismatch persists before the label is revised
- Test whether visible depletion, rather than elapsed time, triggers relabeling

Study design

- n = 214 labelled jars · 9 share-house and office pantries · fortnightly photo audit · 14 weeks
- Refill events logged via a discreet fill-line sticker, matched against the label's named owner by self-report
- Relabeling events (handwriting change) coded as a revision; no threshold was adjusted post hoc

What we found

Match rate holds flat between relabeling events and steps in a single jump at each revision, rather than declining continuously. A jar's declared owner outlasts their last refill by a median 5 weeks before the label is updated.



Aggregate label-refiller match fell from 91% in week 1 to 54% by week 9, recovering only after a fortnightly kitchen clean-up (week 10) relabelled 61% of mismatched jars in a single afternoon.

Implications

Ownership claims persist by default; revision needs an external trigger, not accumulating mismatch. A label functions as a governance artefact independent of the practice it once described. Next: test whether a QR-linked digital label revises itself automatically.

Selected references

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De-identified by jar only; no householder was named or approached. Fill-line data destroyed at audit close.

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“The label outlived the hand that wrote it.”

Match rate fell from 91% to 54% over nine weeks (n = 214 jars, 9 kitchens) before a scheduled clean-up reset it in an afternoon.